

READY TO TAKE OFF
Aircraft at the Indira Gandhi International Airport in Delhi



***K. Ram Mohan Naidu,** Minister of Civil Aviation*

"WE ARE MAKING DELHI AN AIRPORT HUB AS A PILOT PROJECT, AND ALSO PUSHING HYDERABAD AND BENGALURU TO FOLLOW SUIT. WE ARE GETTING ALL STAKEHOLDERS TO WORK HARD ON THIS"

connecting passengers and traffic in what is recognised as the hub-and-spoke model. Aviation experts point out that India, despite its strategic location, has not been able to capitalise on its advantages because we never envisaged our airports as international hubs nor designed them as such from the ground up. Unlike, say, Singapore's Changi airport, which was designed to be an international-to-international (I-I) hub with a focus on space and infrastructure that would suffice for decades to come. Indeed, even its aircraft maintenance facility (part of the hub ecosystem) was designed to be scalable.

With Indian airlines—barring Air India—having neither the capacity nor the wide-bodied aircraft to fly long-haul flights across the world, passengers have had to choose international carriers for point-to-point connectivity. According to an official analysis, only 11 per cent of the passengers take direct flights to destinations in Europe and North America from India. We may currently be the seventh largest market in terms of international passengers carried, but our share in the 'I-I' segment, serving international passengers who fly to an Indian airport for a halt en route to an international destination, is less than 1 per cent. West Asian airports have 11 per cent of the global connecting traffic, with Doha in Qatar serving nearly 75 per cent of its total passengers through international transfer flights. So, business is emerging from India, but not only are Indian carriers losing a sizeable market to foreign counterparts, international hubs are also gaining in revenue from airport charges, fuel, business and tourism etc.

WINGS OF CHANGE

Hence India's efforts to build a hub for itself. The time, as civil aviation minister K. Ram Mohan Naidu says, is now. "Delhi, Bengaluru and Hyderabad—we are pushing them into becoming hubs," he told INDIA TODAY. The civil aviation ministry had shared a draft policy with key industry stakeholders for comments. It has also met the country's major airport operators as well as officials from the Central Industrial Security Force and the Bureau of Immigration to discuss possible changes in airport interior design, and new technologies to expedite immigration and security check processes for international travellers. Naidu admits it's not something that can be achieved overnight. "It takes time. Airlines, airport operators and the ministry, we're all working towards this," he says.

The Indira Gandhi International (IGI) airport in Delhi, the busiest in the country, has been chosen for the pilot. The government has also identified Air India and IndiGo, the country's two largest carriers, as potential partners to carry the weight of this vision. "India has the potential to accommodate at least three hubs and a plethora of point-to-point services," Air India CEO Campbell Wilson said at an industry event last year in Gurugram. "There are few markets globally akin to India. North India witnesses a substantial east-to-west flow, whereas the South can facilitate flows from Asia to Africa or Australia-Europe." But what does it take to be a global aviation hub? Well, right now, about 130 million international passengers fly over India annually; 10 per cent of this transit traffic is handled by Dubai, Doha airport gets a 7.5 per cent share. Delhi, unfortunately, gets less than one per cent share. So what will it take for Delhi to join the big boys?

TERMINAL SIZE AND INFRASTRUCTURE

Over the past few years, IGI has been focusing on augmenting capacity. Terminal 3 can now handle 44 million passengers per annum (MPPA), which compares favourably with the 43 MPPA that Dubai's Terminal 3 handles. After renovations, Terminal 1 of IGI now has enhanced capacity, up to 40 MPPA from 17 MPPA. The capacity at Terminal 2 remains 17 MPPA, but IGI intends to eventually integrate it with the others. Combined, the total capacity of IGI's three terminals will be 100 MPPA, overtaking the 93 MPPA capacity America's Hartsfield-Jackson Atlanta International Airport boasted in 2022, and the combined 90 MPPA capacity of Changi's four terminals.

Infrastructure-wise, though, IGI has some way to go to meet the global benchmarks set by the major hubs in our neighbourhood. In terms of physical size, T3's 5.4 million sq. ft area falls far short